funding of the PTI, from unidentified sources as well as foreign entities, both prohibited under Pakistani laws. The ECP has published a damning report of its investigation and hearings, which carried on for eight long years. The ECP report's findings are that the PTI not only concealed bank accounts, received funding that falls afoul of the law and that monies were illegally diverted, but also that Imran, as the party chairman, gave materially false affidavits. The PTI has challenged the ECP report in the courts but, were the charges to stick, it faces a confiscation of the funds, which run into crores of rupees at the very minimum. The worst case scenario could even see Imran and his party facing a ban.

Another case relates to Imran, as PM, making profits from expensive diplomatic gifts that he bought at highly concessional rates from the state storehouse (the *Toshakhana*) and then sold off in the market, but the proceeds of which he never declared in his tax returns. If proven in court, this too has the potential of making him ineligible for elections.

Other allegations also exist—though formal cases have not been filed—that Khan's current wife, Bushra Bibi, and one of her friends served as conduits for bribes for prize bureaucratic postings and for taking money from a land developer who received undue favours from Imran's government.

Another potentially serious case, again not yet filed formally, arises from leaked audio recordings of Imran's former finance minister, Senator Shaukat Tarin, advising the finance ministers of Punjab and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (both provinces governed by PTI or allied governments) to not cooperate with the federal government and write letters reneging on the provinces' commitments to the IMF just before the latter's final board meeting, ostensibly in order to sabotage the desperately-needed tranche from them. Tarin can allegedly be heard saying that the go-ahead for this bit of subterfuge had come from the PTI core committee, which includes Imran. Many rival politicians and analysts have indicated that the attempt was akin to endangering national security.

Then there is the ongoing contempt case. Imran is charged in court with threatening a female judge with dire consequences over the arrest and remand of his chief of staff Shehbaz Gill, who was taken into custody for allegedly trying to cause dissension within the ranks of the army.

While this case was still being heard, Imran said something about the army's senior leadership at a public rally on September 4 that, according to the military, left it "aghast at the defamatory and uncalled-for" statement. Imran was commenting on the upcoming nomination for the next chief of army staff in November, and said that the present government could not be trusted to pick a "strong" and "patriotic" new chief, by implication tarnishing some of the top generals as unpatriotic or lax on corruption. "Regrettably, an attempt has been made to discredit and undermine [the] senior leadership of [the] Pakistan Army at a time when the institution is laying [down] lives for the security and safety of the people of Pakistan every day," the military's spokesperson responded. The fracas led to the Pakistan Electronic Media Regulatory Authority (Pemra) reiterating that none of Imran Khan's rallies could be shown live on television.

Photos: AP



THE PTI BELIEVES THERE IS STILL STRONG SUPPORT IN THE MILITARY FOR IMRAN AND THEIR PROVOCATIVE STATEMENTS ARE AN ATTEMPT TO EXERT PRESSURE ON THE TOP BRASS FROM WITHIN

For now, the powerful military is staying in the background. And while Imran's rhetoric about what he sees as 'betrayal' by the establishment is still couched in euphemisms—he keeps taunting the army top brass as 'neutrals' for having abandoned him—there is a sense among most observers that his relations with the current brass are now too frosty for a patch-up.

The PTI, however, believes there still is a strong cache of support in the military for Imran, and the spate of provocative statements are an attempt to exert pressure on the top brass from within the military. It's a dangerous strategy, because Imran's own preferred general, Lt. Gen. Faiz Hameed, the former head of the Inter-Services Intelligence agency (ISI) who managed the government for the inexperienced Imran for most of his tenure as PM, has been more or less sidelined. It is also supremely ironic, be-